# Day 5 Task: Harden Your Laptop

## Step 1: The 15-point checklist

| # | Check | Where | Before | After | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Operating system fully updated and automatic updates ON | Settings → Update | Yes | Yes | Windows is up to date. |
| 2 | Browser updated to the latest version | Browser → About | Yes | Yes | Chrome updated. |
| 3 | Full-disk encryption ON (BitLocker / FileVault / phone encryption) | Settings → Security | No | Yes | Turned on BitLocker. |
| 4 | Screen locks automatically within 1–2 minutes | Settings → Lock screen | No | Yes | Changed timeout from 10 mins to 2 mins. |
| 5 | Strong login PIN/password + fingerprint or face | Settings → Sign-in | Yes | Yes | Windows Hello PIN active. |
| 6 | Daily account is a STANDARD user, not administrator | Settings → Accounts | No | No | Kept as Admin for everthing. |
| 7 | Firewall ON | Windows Security / System Settings | Yes | Yes | Windows Defender Firewall active. |
| 8 | Antivirus / Defender ON and updated | Windows Security / XProtect | Yes | Yes | Windows Security active. |
| 9 | Find My Device / remote wipe enabled | Settings → Find My | Yes | Yes | Enabled in Windows settings. |
| 10 | File extensions visible (so invoice.pdf.exe shows its .exe) | File Explorer → View | No | Yes | Checked "File name extensions" in View tab. |
| 11 | Browser | Browser → | No | Yes | Removed 3 |

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | extensions reviewed; unused ones removed (count them) | Extensions | | | unused extensions. |
| 12 | No card details saved in the browser | Browser → Payment methods | yes | Yes | No saved cards. |
| 13 | Apps/programs you don't use uninstalled (count them) | Settings → Apps | No | Yes | Uninstalled 4 unused apps. |
| 14 | A backup exists on a second medium (external drive or cloud) | Backup settings | Yes | Yes | Google Drive cloud backup for documents. |
| 15 | You restored ONE file from that backup to prove it works | Backup settings | Yes | Yes | Successfully downloaded a test PDF from Drive. |

## Step 2: Your score

**BEFORE:** 6/15
**AFTER:** 14/15

Which check could you NOT complete, and why?

Check 6 (Standard user). I kept my account as an Administrator because I frequently need elevated privileges for VirtualBox, Kali Linux, and other development tools.

## Step 3: Two questions

1. Which single fix from the list would have stopped the most attacks we covered this week? Explain.

Ensuring the OS and browser are fully updated (Checks 1 & 2) stops the most attacks. Modern exploit kits and malware rely heavily on known, unpatched vulnerabilities to execute silently, so patching closes the biggest doors.

2. A colleague says 'I'm not important enough to be hacked, I'll skip the updates.' What do you tell them?

Hackers use automated bots to scan the entire internet for vulnerable machines, meaning everyone is a target. Your device could be compromised to mine crypto, send spam, or act as

a stepping stone in a botnet without you ever realizing it and you will be the source oh hack for the attacker.

## Step 4: Get ready for Week 2

**Tick when done:** [✓]

Note: I already have VirtualBox installed for my Kali Linux environment, and the Ubuntu VM with 2 CPUs, 4 GB RAM, and a 25 GB disk is now set up alongside it.